





FITNESS AND EXERCISE EXPERTS

Earnings

- Entry level: \$30,000 annually
- Median level: \$40,000
- Specialists certification: \$50,000
- Self-employed: \$45,000
- Employed by the government: \$65,000
- High end: \$80,000

Traits Required

- Knowledge of exercise & training methods
- Know the human anatomy
- Communication skills
- Good physical condition

The Work You Will Do

- Instruct clients in methods of exercise
- Determine clients eating habits
- Marketing

Where You Will Work

- Health clubs
- Client's homes
- Personal training facilities
- Community wellness & recreation centers
- Corporate headquarters

Education Required

- Certificate
- Bachelor of Science
- Master of Science

Attractive Features

- Feeling of personal accomplishment
- Do what you love
- Help people improve their quality of life
- Freedom
- Earning potential
- Job security

Unattractive Features

- Physically demanding
- Hectic schedule

- Illness & injury
- Danger of liability for injury

OceanofPDF.com

Introduction

The average person cannot do it alone, though. With all of the fad diets and quick-fix schemes on the market these days, it can be difficult for an individual to turn good intentions into results. That is where the personal fitness trainer enters the picture. A personal trainer is for the most part a guide on the road to fitness. They are people who know how to keep fit and make a living out of helping people improve their physiques. With out society rapidly becoming more health-aware, this career option has become one of the hottest vocational fields.

If you are the type of person who likes to exercise and who knows how to maintain a healthy lifestyle, and you would like to make a good income while sharing your knowledge with a fitness-hungry clientele, then by all means consider exploring a career as a personal trainer.

What You Can Do Now

Trainers in training can also meet with or volunteer to assist other personal trainers in their area, thus observing and learning the process first-hand.

Exercising is also important, as it allows a future personal trainer to keep fit while also gaining an intimate understanding of how each exercise is performed.

History of the Career

Lance C. Dalleck and Dr. Len Kravitz, authors of *The History of Fitness*, state that the early teachings of Confucius encouraged people to regularly participate in physical activity in order to stave off specific ailments which sound similar to heart disease and diabetes. Gymnastics, archery, badminton, dancing, fencing, and wrestling were also common methods of fitness training during this time period.

There is evidence that weight training was practiced in ancient Egypt and India, while the Greeks left numerous sculptures and illustrations of their athletes training with stone weights. During the sixth-century BC - known as the Age of Strength - athletic competitions were regularly held in which the competitors would lift massive stones. In this era, an ancient physician named Galen completed a work called *The Preservation of Health* in which he referred to two different categories of physical training - quick (those done without weights) and violent (those performed with weights).

The Persian Empire was a culture which demanded its citizens to maintain a high level of fitness through strength and stamina training. The intended benefit of such training was to create a group of superior soldiers, and it was undoubtedly successful as the Persians at one time had conquered nearly all of the Near East.

The Renaissance was another era in which the popularity of fitness training increased. The renewed appreciation for human life, which evolved during the Renaissance, created an

environment which was ready for the widespread development of physical education throughout Europe. Intellectual leaders of the time, including religious leader Martin Luther and philosopher John Locke, believed that maintaining a high fitness level helped to enhance one's intellectual capabilities. The first books on weight training and the first university courses on physical fitness also came about during this era.

Following the Renaissance was a period of fierce nationalism among European countries that lasted until the mid-1800s. The perception that physical fitness was vital to success did not change, but the competitive atmosphere in Europe is said to have given birth to the first modern fitness movement - gymnastics. Also during this time, Swede Per Henrik Ling became the first person to use the science of physiology to measure the affect of exercise on the human body.

The Birth of American Physical Education

The Founding Fathers of the United States recognized the importance of keeping fit. Benjamin Franklin recommended regular physical activity, including running, swimming, and basic forms of resistance training for health purposes. Additionally, President Thomas Jefferson advised individuals to exercise for at least two hours a day, regardless of the weather conditions.

Physical education in the modern sense would not come about in America until after the Civil War, when public schools and universities were established in great numbers during the latter half of the 19th century. According to Dr. Alison Wrynn, author of *The History of American Health, Hygiene and Fitness*, Edward Hitchcock of Amherst College became the nation's first collegiate professor in Hygiene and Physical Fitness in 1861.

The concepts behind individualized fitness education continued to grow from this point on, laying the foundation for modern-day personal training. In 1885, the organization that would come to be known as the American Association for the Advancement of Physical Education (AAAPE) held its first meeting. By 1896, the AAAPPE published its first professional journal, which was called the American Physical Education Review. A trio of additional fitness-oriented organizations were formed between 1897 and 1907, and as the US prepared to enter World War I, many prominent physical educators recommended that schools require physical education classes in order to aid American's preparations for the upcoming conflict.

Following the war, key figures in the profession began to push for certification requirements of physical education teachers. However, this would not officially come about until 1954. That year also marked the establishment of the American College of Sports Medicine.

Two Important Figures In Fitness Training History

Jack LaLanne is the man generally considered America's first nationally recognized fitness trainer. He began his career during the Great Depression in the 1930s, but gained most of his fame and exposure through his television show in the 1950s.

LaLanne was a true pioneer in the fitness field. In 1936, at the age of 21, he opened the first public gym in the United States. He introduced the first cable-pulley machine, the first Smith machine for squats, and the first machine for leg-extension exercises. LaLanne was also the pioneer of the jumping jack, and developed an array of training programs during his career, including

regimens focused on aerobic-style exercises, water training, and strength resistance exercises.

His programs may be roughly 50 years old, but the quality of his instruction was such that reruns of his television show are still shown today on ESPN Classic. Currently, the nearly 90-year-old [Jack La Lanne](#) tours the country as a motivational speaker and communicates with fans through his official website

The man most widely recognized as the Father of the Modern Fitness Movement is Dr. Kenneth H. Cooper, whom many experts believe was responsible for encouraging more individuals to exercise than anyone else in the nation's history. Cooper coined the term aerobics with the publication of his 1968 book under that title. While serving as an Air Force flight surgeon and the director of the Aerospace Medical Laboratory in San Antonio, Texas, Dr. Cooper developed both the 12-minute fitness test and the Aerobics Point System, which today are used by the US Army and Navy, as well as the Secret Service, several foreign militaries, and corporations and schools across the globe. Cooper believed that medicine should focus on disease prevention instead of disease treatment, and his book Aerobics was a blueprint for maintaining good health through exercise, diet, and emotional balance. Today, he serves as the President of the [Cooper Aerobics Center](#), a health and fitness complex located in Dallas, Texas.

Where You Will Work

Wherever the location, most of a personal trainer's work will take place inside an area designed specifically for the type of exercises that the client will participate in. Personal trainers focusing on weight training will need to have barbells, dumbbells, and other training machines that will help clients to gain muscle mass on their arms, chests, legs, and other body parts. Aerobics instructors and other fitness educators will need to have equipment suited to their training styles, such as inflated balls, jump ropes, and step platforms. Anyone who is active in exercise and is interested in becoming a personal fitness trainer already knows the type of location and equipment he/she will need to get started, although improvements and additions will be necessary in the future.

In addition, many personal trainers have offices where they meet with new and potential clients, complete business-related paperwork, and organize the daily operations of the business. For ease of operation, these offices are more often than not attached to or located near the actual place of training.

The Work You Will Do

Some clients may even have the misguided notion that it will be easy to get in shape, influenced by all of the television commercials and programs that make training look like a cakewalk. Whatever the focus of a personal trainer's business, he/she should be prepared to deal with clients who balk at the hard work involved in the exercise portion of the training regiment.

There are many different types of training programs to choose from. Some trainers will decide to focus on one or a small number of these exercise styles, while others will strive to be more versatile and offer a number of different training options. The choice is up to the individual trainer, and careerists should remember that repertoires can be expanded or changed at any time during one's career.

One of the most popular training styles is weight training, which involves using dumbbells or weighted barbells in exercises designed to add muscle mass to the chest, back, arms, legs, and other regions of the body. Another is aerobic training, which are any of the well-known routines that involve lots of rhythmic motion to keep the heart rate up. In reality, there is a wide array of exercise types - ranging from weightlifting and basic aerobics to running, swimming, and sports-based training, to currently popular exercise trends like dance, kick boxing, and martial arts based training. Yoga and Pilates round out the mix.

Practicing these styles correctly can require thorough instruction. In fact, teaching exercises is one of the most important aspects of

a trainer's job. Just how much instruction is involved? "Tons!" claims one personal trainer interviewed for this report. "Most people don't know a barbell row from a deadlift, and the trainer must be prepared to show their clients the proper form, technique, and position for each and every exercise. I strongly suggest the trainer perform each new exercise for clients before they try it (and several times after that) to make sure they have the movement down. Make sure after you show the exercise to give your clients time to ask questions, and don't be afraid to correct them during the movement, or even halt them if they are doing the exercise completely wrong."

While the exercise portion of the training business is vital, it is actually not the first step. Before a client does even a single push-up or touches the first weight, it is essential for the trainer and the individual to work together to develop a set of fitness goals. Such exercise goals should be measurable and short-term in nature, as clients will feel compelled to state unrealistic goals like "I want to get to 3-percent body fat!" or "I want to look like Arnold Schwarzenegger at his prime!" However, trainers should point out that clients must focus on goals that can be achieved in a short period of time, such as losing just a certain few pounds of weight in a month, or adding a certain amount of weights or length of time to a particular exercise. Achieving short-term, attainable goals like these help keep clients focused without losing interest or becoming discouraged and quitting (and losing the trainer a client).

Determining a Client's Eating Habits

As any reliable personal trainer or exercise enthusiast knows, exercise is worthless without establishing a proper diet and developing good eating habits. Clients will most likely have their

own ideas about what kind of diet they should be on, as the term itself has in popular use come to mean any reduction in the amount of food eaten and/or limitation on the types of foods consumed. These clients will be surprised to learn that personal trainers view food as essential fuel for the body and create a variety of dietary plans based upon the desired results. It is not easy to change a person's viewpoint about matters of eating, however. In fact, because of the confusion over so many of the so-called miracle diets out there today, and unwillingness to strictly adhere to a specific menu, getting a client to eat properly may be the toughest challenge facing a personal trainer.

Most trainers tend to develop dietary plans that involve between five and seven meals per day, with two to three hour intervals between meals, because this particular eating schedule helps the body process nutrients faster while reducing the amount of fat stored. Trainers also need to understand and explain the way different nutrients affect the body, and how the amount of each should be carefully monitored and adjusted based upon individual fitness goals. For instance, protein rebuilds damaged muscle tissue and helps add muscle tissue. Carbohydrates, even though many trendy diets say otherwise, are actually the preferred source of fuel for the body and must be consumed for the body to function properly. Exercise professionals know all about proteins and carbohydrates, as well as the importance of consuming enough fats and water.

Selling a client on a diet can be difficult, especially if the diet plan flies in the face of popular opinion. Those looking to lose weight may have trouble accepting that fact that the scale is not always the best way to measure success. Improper diet can lead to loss of muscle mass, which would show up on a scale but in reality

does the client no good. Clients must trust the personal trainer enough to accept the fact that it is body fat percentage (measured by a device known as a caliper) that is the true test of an improving physique. A trainer must convince clients that many of those attractive, popular diets that lead to sudden weight loss may actually lower the metabolism, making it harder to keep the weight off and remain physically fit. A fat-loss diet may not even be in a client's best long-term interest. Clients looking to gain muscle should actually eat more than normal (an estimated 500 extra calories or more over the individual's basic metabolic rate) of protein-rich foods.

It takes a lot of observation and work to calculate and design a diet that is just right for each client, but it might even be more difficult to convince that client of what may seem to be a radical change in eating habits. You will have to show the client the process involved in creating a diet plan. Explain, in layman's terms, what the impact of different diet plans will be for his/her unique body type. When possible, show prior examples of how the diet plan helped fellow clients or other people to achieve results similar to that which the client is seeking. Measure success frequently using a caliper and remind the client of the progress made. This keeps the individual motivated and focused on the short-term goals - and making regular visits to the trainer.

Record-Keeping and Other Business-Related Tasks

Personal training isn't all about physical activity and diet planning. There is paperwork involved - especially those who are self-employed. Like any business owner, a personal trainer must rigorously keep track of earned income and expenses for tax purposes. Each time a client pays the hourly rate or a flat fee for a certain number of sessions, it must be recorded. When new

gym equipment, fitness supplements, or any other item that will be used in the business practice is purchased, it too must be logged.

Personal trainers may be responsible for scheduling client sessions and handling other small business related bookkeeping matters, such as payroll services, if the trainer has any subordinate employees.

One type of paperwork is exclusive to this particular vocation - the training journal, which is a record of every client's individual progress. Exercise enthusiasts already tend to keep track of their own personal progress, but those who enter the physical education field professionally will also have to undertake the responsibility of helping every one of their clients maintain such a record. By keeping track of the client's raw statistics and taking notes about his/her progress, a trainer will be able to see what works for each individual and what does not. A fitness journal needs to include all of the exercises performed in a given session, including the weight used (when applicable), the number of sets and the amount of repetitions included in each set. Clients should also add an entry every time they eat, listing the number of times they eat, the types of food, and the number of calories, proteins, carbohydrates, and fats included in each meal. Sections should also be included on the client's daily physical condition (how he/ she feels), body weight, fat percentage, and body measurements. All of this information is used to help the client achieve optimal results from a trainer's services.

The Professionals Speak

I am now a trainer at a gym, and I have some in-home clients. Although some days are booked from 6AM to 2PM (my idea of a perfect schedule) most are long because clients are scattered throughout the day. I might spend 6AM to 9 AM at the gym, then travel to a few in-home clients houses, then have several hours off in the afternoon, and finally return to the gym (or to in-home clients) during the evening. This rough schedule is partly because I'm still fairly new in this field. Eventually, I will be able to arrange my hours according to my wishes. But you have to keep in mind that prime training hours are early morning and after work. The middle of the afternoon is pretty dead. I train in both one hour and half hour increments. I also have a small group training session twice a week with beginning runners.

Since I didn't decide on becoming a trainer until I was in my thirties, I didn't major in sports science in college. My degrees were in English and journalism. I found a reputable place that offered an eight-week training course (64 hours total of classroom and hands-on training). I also took a job at a gym before being certified just 'walking the floor.' So that provided me with some hands-on training. We're required to take continuing education every year to keep our certification current.

When I was in college I didn't really realize this could be an career option for me. I was taught that you go to college; take business, law, literature, science; go to grad school and get a good, steady desk job. I wish I had had the foresight to study sports science or recreation in college, and I would highly recommend you do if this is your field of interest.

What do I enjoy most about my work? It is hard to name just one thing - the independence, being active and on my feet all day, talking with different clients every hour, the time it allows me to train for races. On the negative side, I am currently making less than half of what I was when working for the government. That will improve, but it takes some time. Right now, my schedule is tiring. I get up around 4:30AM and sometimes get home at 9PM. And you have to be a salesperson too - that's never been one of my strong suits. I think I'm a very good trainer, but I'm a lousy salesperson. I'm not good at making the hard sale.

If you're serious about a career in fitness training, then get your certification from one of the reputable companies (in other words, don't just take an online test, pass it, and declare yourself a trainer). Take some classes with a hands-on trainer rather than just studying the written text. Watch other trainers. I contacted trainers while I was taking classes and asked if I could watch them. Most were open to it. If you're in college now and know this is what you want to do, take the appropriate courses. Oh, and if you're leaving a full-time day job to do this, save AT LEAST a full year of living expenses to carry you until you're making enough from your new career."

I Am a Personal Trainer and an Amateur Bodybuilding Champion

"How did I first get interested in this career? I guess you could say I was raised into it. My Dad was a bodybuilder before me, and I can't honestly remember a time when there wasn't a gym in the house. Training seemed like the natural thing for me to do, and I worked very hard to learn as much about it as I could. As I got older, I found that many people who desired to be fit didn't have the first idea how to achieve their goals, so I saw the potential to

make a living by guiding these individuals in what I already loved to do!

The first thing I do each day is go over the client list for the day and see who's on my schedule, and then review each trainee's individual training journals to plan what that day's workouts will be. I try to get the paperwork end of the job taken care of early in the day so my clients have my full attention while I'm working with them. During the actual workouts, I guide and spot them through each exercise, making sure that each movement is performed correctly and within their capabilities. At the end of each trainee's workout, I also review their goals, check their body fat and weight (weekly), and fine-tune and critique their diet. Not all trainers take diet into consideration, but I find it to be an essential part of the whole fitness equation.

I am an International Sports Sciences Association certified Fitness Trainer (www.issaonline.com). The certification must be kept up yearly with continuing education, either at seminars or with online classes. Another organization that is very well respected is the [Aerobics and Fitness Association of America](http://www.aerobicsandfitness.org) or ACE (www.acefitness.org/default.aspx). Anyone seeking to be a fitness trainer should at the very least have one certification in personal training from an accredited organization like these two, and it's desirable that you also have some of the specialist certifications, such as youth training, fitness therapist, plus some dietary or nutrition background. There are many organizations out there that offer fitness certification that are not accredited or accepted, and it would be unwise to waste you time on those companies. Make sure your certification is well accepted.

In personal training, I do what I love to do. It's always best if you can make a living from something that you enjoy. I enjoy helping people better themselves, and watch as they improve their bodies. Usually, you are your own boss and can directly affect your own income by how much time and effort you wish to put forward. The schedule can be flexible, so if you require a day off, you should be able to arrange it. But that 'I am my own boss' thing swings both ways. There is no steady paycheck, so you only earn money when you have clients. That means that there needs to be self promotion in this profession.

Personal training can make for long days, as a good trainer will cater to the client's schedule, not his own. You have to accommodate many types of schedules, and it's very likely you'll have one client only able to train at 6AM, and another at 8PM.

Never allow yourself to believe that you know all about personal fitness training. Always try to learn more from the experts in the field, and also learn from your clients. They know their bodies better than you do. This profession is ever changing and ever growing. Those trainers unwilling to adapt their ways to meet their clients' expectations and needs will fail.

Make sure that all of you clients are cleared to train through their personal physician. As their trainer, you have responsibility to your clients to make sure that they stay healthy and free from injury."

I Developed Physical Fitness Standards for Law Enforcement and SWAT Teams

"I developed fitness standards based on what physical activity a SWAT officer and police officer may have to perform during a tour of duty. Both SWAT and police need to have muscular

endurance, muscular strength and aerobic fitness. Additionally, they need to be tested on exercises that mirror tasks that they may have to perform such as squeezing through a window, dragging a downed officer to safety, running up several flights of stairs with heavy gear, and climbing over fences.

I first became interested in fitness training during the late 1980s and early 1990s. I read an interesting article which stated that the fitness industry does not have any limitations and will continue to grow. Additionally, the fact that numerous people would constantly ask me questions pertaining to training inspired me to research the personal training field further. Before I landed a full-time job as a police supervisor, I owned and ran my own training business. These days, I currently only take on part-time personal training for those serious about a lifestyle change.

I typically deal with finding new and innovative ways to motivate and peek the interest of my clients on a day to day basis so that they stay focused on their goals and continue to enjoy their workouts. Some of the duties involved in personal fitness training include engaging and consulting with new clients, managing accounts, following up with phone calls to clients and staying educated on the newest training information.

Educationally, I pursued a nationally recognized personal training certification that requires annual testing for renewal. Additionally, I attend various seminars and fitness courses throughout the year. I also read reputable periodicals to stay up on the latest cutting edge training and nutritional recommendations.

For others pursuing a career in fitness training, I would recommend achieving a training certification from a reputable

company at a minimum. I would also recommend a two or four-year degree in a related field since that seems to be the future trend. One important attribute that a trainer should have is 'in the trenches' training experience. The training experience that you obtain through life experiences in the gym is worth its weight in gold.

I enjoy meeting new people and helping them achieve their goals. When they feel better, I feel better. However, not all people are motivated or think positive. It is difficult to deal with clients who just want to go through the motions and do not really want to be at the gym or training. A very big negative. I can be choosy about who I accept as a client, but most trainers take all comers.

If you're passionate about fitness and helping others I would definitely recommend a personal training career. Set the example for your clients by looking the part and motivating them through your words and actions. Don't forget to get that 'in the trenches' experience. Experiment with new training techniques and equipment but remember that the basics are the best foundation for any fitness program. Don't get caught up in the newest, fancy training machine or supplement. Use them as tools and implement them for variety but stick to the basics that have worked for years."

Personal Qualifications

Communication skills are also vital in this career field. Like a sports coach, a personal trainer is in many ways a teacher, instructing individuals on proper exercise and diet techniques and methods. A trainer must be able to clearly explain and, if necessary, illustrate the different programs. Some of these may be complicated concepts; nonetheless, it is a trainer's job to instruct clients in the theory and methodology of physical education. For this reason, it is important that a personal trainer have excellent oral and written communication skills. Sometimes teaching will occur in the gym (especially when it comes to new exercises) and sometimes instruction needs to be written for later reference (plan for a person's diet, for example).

Communication skills are also needed to sell potential clients on your services. Unless you are employed by a large health club and have clients assigned to you, marketing yourself to individual clients is a vital aspect of the personal training.

A personal trainer must also never forget that this is a business, and you must be willing and able to perform business-related tasks. Basic accounting and bookkeeping chores are components of any business venture, and there is certainly no underestimating the value of possessing computer skills.

There are many hours of hard work required in this vocation, both in the gym and outside of it, so an tireless work ethic will be a valuable quality - as will flexibility, to deal with changes in appointment hours and clientele.

Every personal trainer will benefit greatly by being strong, healthy, and athletic, not just because the work can be physically demanding but also your appearance will help promote the business. Your apparent success in training yourself will provide a good demonstration of your ability for future customers.

OceanofPDF.com

Attractive Features

The majority of personal trainers do what they do because they love keeping fit themselves, and they want to help others get in shape as well. Individuals who pursue a career in this field love to exercise. They enjoy lifting weights, doing aerobics and pursuing similar exercise-related activities, and most likely these people would continue to work out even if they were not employed as fitness professionals. Some of them even compete in or judge a variety of fitness-related competitions, such as marathons, bodybuilding shows or aerobics contests, depending on their primary interests. Many personal trainers find joy in sharing their knowledge with others and helping people to improve their quality of life. Enjoyment of the work and the feeling gained by assisting other people in improving their physiques are two of the primary features that draw people into the profession.

Many personal trainers choose to be self-employed, a definite career advantage for those individuals who want to be their own boss and set their own work hours. Being self-employed also gives a personal trainer the ability to take time off as needed - so long as the upcoming schedule of client sessions can be cleared.

Freedom, earning potential, job security, and the ability to do what you love while helping others improve the quality of their lives - all of these factors combine to make this a very attractive career choice for fitness-minded individuals.

Unattractive Features

Self-employed trainers typically have to handle every aspect of their businesses, which means time that could be spent exercising or training a client will sometimes have to be devoted to other less interesting aspects of running a business.

Without clients, there would be no business, so actively recruiting new business and handling the creation and distribution of advertising materials can be essential. Every business owner needs to keep track of the business's finances, including earnings, expenses, equipment and operating expenses, and taxes. A self-employed personal trainer needs to be as adept at working out business details as working out physiques.

This is also a physically demanding vocation. A fitness trainer must be in excellent physical condition for a number of reasons. First of all, a trainer's physique is an effective selling point for new clients. A client will likely not sign with a trainer unless the trainer's own physical condition illustrates that the program produces results. Additionally, a trainer often will need to demonstrate an exercise to a client, which means that the trainer must at all times be physically prepared to do so. Given the hectic schedule that a trainer could possibly face, that means that he/she must be prepared to perform an exercise morning, noon and night.

Illness and injury are the banes of this vocation, because not only will a short-term setback play havoc with a session schedule, but a long term illness or a severe injury could cripple the business by keeping a trainer out of the gym for weeks or months.

Another unattractive and potentially disastrous aspect of working as a personal trainer is the danger of liability for injury. Any time a personal trainer works with a client, the trainer is responsible for inducing physiological change in the body of that client. It is absolutely vital that a trainer have a potential client sign a waiver or release form to protect the instructor in case of injury, and a personal trainer must also first obtain a thorough medical history before beginning or even designing any exercise program. Even then, an injury or medical emergency may occur, and then the personal trainer could have to defend against negligence charges in a court of law.

OceanofPDF.com

Required Education and Training

College Programs

Many colleges and universities offer specialized programs for those looking to pursue such a career, including degrees in exercise science or exercise physiology, kinesiology, or physical education. These programs can range from certificate programs, to Bachelor of Science or Master of Science degrees, to doctorates. These courses of study are intended to prepare you to work within the health and fitness field, with a focus on individual exercise instruction and the development of a new, healthy lifestyle for clients.

According to information obtained by Oakland Community College, students completing their Exercise Science & Technology program have gone on to hold many different fitness-related careers, including as personal trainers, health club management, youth center fitness coordinators and sports coaches.

Individual courses in these programs of study vary depending on the type of degree and the university offering the curriculum. However, at nearly every school, there is a core of exercise science courses at the heart of the curriculum. Some of the exercise science, nutritional science and physical education courses you can expect to participate in include:

- Methods and Materials of Physical Education
- Research Methods in Physical Education
- Wellness and Risk Reduction Concepts
- Physiological Chemistry of Exercise
- Exercise and Nutrition

- Mental and Behavioral Aspects of Sports
- Legal Aspects of Sport and Therapeutic Modalities in Sports Medicine

Some colleges and universities also require students to take English, communication, humanities, marketing, psychology and/or sociology courses to complete a degree.

Certification

In addition to your schooling, certification by a valid fitness certification and education provider is an equally important form of preparation for a would-be personal trainer. There are many, many different organizations across the country and around the world, each offering professional certification for fitness trainers. They include:

- [Aerobics and Fitness Association of America](#)
- [American Fitness Professionals & Associates](#)
- [International Fitness Professionals Association](#)

Each organization - and the many others like them in existence - offers different types of certification and hold their members to a different set of standards.

The [Aerobics and Fitness Association of America](#) (ACE) claims to be the largest nonprofit fitness certification provider in the world. It is also one of the most respected within the personal trainer community. The ACE was established in 1985 and has certified more than 200,000 health and fitness professionals in the United States as well as many other countries. It is one of two bodies in the fitness industry whose educational programs have been accredited by the National Commission for Certifying Agencies.

The ACE offers more than 300 different fitness certification programs for training professionals of varying levels.

American Fitness Professionals & Associates (AFPA) courses provide the information required for individuals to implement a one-on-one fitness program that is safe and effective for training clients in gyms, health clubs, and other similar environments. AFPA certification requires an individual to be at least 18 years of age and a high school graduate, while also possessing a basic understanding of anatomy and cardiovascular and strength/resistance training methods and equipment. Topics covered by the AFPA Personal Trainer Home Study Certification program include:

- Cardiovascular Health & Fitness
- Muscle Physiology, Fatigue and Performance
- Exercise Programming for Seniors, Children, and Pre/Post Natal clients
- First Aid and Emergency Protocols

Basic personal trainer certification through the AFPA costs about \$300, and advanced programs are also available.

The [International Fitness Professionals Association](#) (IFPA) offers several different levels of personal fitness trainer certification, from basic to master level as well as specializations in sports nutrition, weight management, specific sports, and senior and youth fitness. The core IFPA Personal Fitness Trainer Certification Program is designed to teach and test on the most vital data utilized to train people in gyms, health clubs, and similar one-on-one training environments. Among the topics covered by IFPA certification are muscle physiology; metabolism; training principles; body composition analysis; psychology, motivation

and ethics; and fitness-related business and law courses. The large number of certification options makes the IFPA a good choice for those looking to specialize in a certain area of personal fitness training.

The International Sports Sciences Association (ISSA) also offers a variety of certification options in addition to their basic Certified Fitness Trainer program. Among them are the Specialist in Performance Nutrition, Fitness Therapist, Specialist in Fitness for Older Adults, Specialist in Sports Conditioning, Youth Fitness Trainer, Endurance Fitness Trainer, Specialist in Martial Arts Conditioning, and Water Fitness Trainer certification programs. Since 1988, the ISSA has provided certification and continuing education for more than 50,000 fitness professionals across the globe. The ISSA claims to be the first organization in the country to offer personal training certification and to create specialized courses for fitness professionals.

It is strongly recommended that an aspiring fitness trainer research these and other organizations thoroughly before deciding which certification or certifications to invest time and money in. Obtaining the proper certification is a key element to finding initial and lasting success as a personal trainer, and it is not a decision that should be taken lightly by anyone entering the field.

If your desire is to go to college to become a fitness expert below are school with physical education programs:

- [Elmhurst College](#)
- [Gonzaga University](#)
- [Louisiana Tech University](#)
- [Seattle Pacific University](#)

[OceanofPDF.com](https://oceanofpdf.com)

Earnings

The median earnings of exercise professionals and personal fitness trainers in are reported to be over \$15 per hour, with many earning \$25. The highest earners pull over \$35 per hour.

Those who are self-employed tend to earn more than those employed by a gym, fitness center, or related firm.

The highest paid fitness trainers and aerobics instructors tend to be those with at least 10, up to 20 years of experience. Individuals falling into this category earn a median salary of \$40,000. Those just starting out in the field still earn an income of over \$30,000.

Those who hold a CPR certification or are certified water specialists can earn upwards of \$50,000.

Employee exercise program instructors working for businesses employing fewer than 100 workers have a median income of \$40,000. Those employed by larger companies can earn up to \$80,000.

Self-employed fitness trainers and aerobics instructors earn a median income of \$45,000, second only to those employed by the government, who are paid about \$65,000.

Opportunities

Other sources substantiate those figures as well. According to US government employment experts, job openings for fitness trainers and aerobic instructors are expected to be well over the norm due to the rapid growth of the industry. An increasing number of people are expected to spend more time and money on exercise and fitness-related activities, and it is anticipated that more and more businesses will begin to offer such services to their employees.

Some sections of personal training have grown faster than others. Pilates, yoga, core conditioning, and stability ball exercises are currently the fastest-growing fitness trends in the United States. According to a recent survey from one fitness association, the percentage of fitness training and instruction providers offering Pilates classes has increased from 10 percent in 1997 to 65 percent today. Also during that time period, the number of trainers offering stability ball classes rose from 28 percent to 71 percent. Also on the increase is the number of fitness facilities offering one-on-one personal training, with over 70 percent now offering such services.

That does this trend mean to those seeking a career in this field? "The increased interest in personal training suggests that consumers are realizing that noteworthy results in exercise come from systematic and structured fitness plans developed by qualified and experienced professionals," states Dr. Kravitz, co-author of *The History of Fitness and the Senior Exercise Physiologist* for IDEA. He also claims that the growth of programs like Pilates and yoga "indicates that consumers are enthusiastic

about physical activity programs that integrate body and mind and help to contribute to an overall increase in the quality of life of the participant." Clearly, the numbers do not lie - personal fitness training is a solid career choice with plenty of job opportunities available, and it should remain so for years to come.

OceanofPDF.com

Getting Started

Many trainers choose to obtain more than one certification. While this is not technically necessary, doing so can only help one's career prospects. As a general rule, the more education and training an individual pursues, the more employable he/she will become, so an aspiring personal trainer would do well to consider pursuing certification by multiple governing bodies.

From there, the road to becoming a personal trainer splits into different pathways. Those individuals looking to run their own training operation are free to start advertising and soliciting clients as soon as they are certified and feel comfortable with the day-to-day duties of a personal trainer. Others may want to work for a health club or fitness center, in which case these individuals should check the classified ads of their local newspapers or with the human resources representatives at nearby exercise locations. According to a recent report in the Los Angeles Times, most trainers who work within a gym or health club tend to work part time at least at first, and some earn a percentage of a client's fee instead of an hourly rate or weekly salary. It is important to do research and understand a fitness center's approach to hiring people to train their members before agreeing to terms of employment. Keep in mind as well that this is not a lifelong commitment - a personal trainer can start off self-employed before joining the staff of a health care facility, and later move back.

In addition, there are several different online sources to help you find employment. Some fitness associations carry job announcement ads on their websites. This is a good way to find

solid, trustworthy job leads, and it can even give a trainer an advantage should he/she be certified by the organization carrying the position opening.

OceanofPDF.com

Associations, Periodical and Websites

- [Aerobics and Fitness Association of America](#)
- [American Council on Exercise](#)
- [American Fitness Professionals & Associates](#)
- [Canadian Association of Fitness Professionals](#)
- [IDEA Health & Fitness Association](#)
- [International Fitness Association](#)
- [International Fitness Professionals Association](#)
- [National Council on Strength & Fitness](#)
- [National Exercise Trainers Association](#)
- [National Federation of Personal Trainers](#)
- [National Strength & Conditioning Association](#)
- [Natural Fitness Trainers Association](#)

Listed below are some trade periodicals

- [Flex](#)
- [Ironman Magazine](#)
- [Men's Health](#)
- [Muscle & Fitness](#)
- [Muscle & Fitness Hers](#)
- [Personal Fitness Professional](#)
- [Total Health Magazine](#)

Websites

- [About.com - Exercise](#)
- [Career Center for Fitness Professionals](#)
- [Fitness Online](#)
- [Personal Fitness Professional](#)
- [Truly Huge - Bodybuilding, Health and Fitness Site](#)

**Careers Research Reports Copyright 2018 by The Institute For
Career Research**

OceanofPDF.com